Englander about the invention of the telegraph stated, ‘It is impossible that old prejudices and hostilities should longer exist, while such an instrument has been created for an exchange of thought between all the nations of the earth.’[4] Nearly two centuries and two world wars later, Mark Zuckerberg said that Facebook’s goal ‘is to help people to share more in order to make the world more open and to help promote understanding between people’.[5]

In his 2024 book, *The Singularity Is Nearer*, the eminent futurologist and entrepreneur Ray Kurzweil surveys the history of information technology and concludes that ‘the reality is that nearly every aspect of life is getting progressively better as a result of exponentially improving technology’. Looking back at the grand sweep of human history, he cites examples like the invention of the printing press to argue that by its very nature information technology tends to spawn ‘a virtuous circle advancing nearly every aspect of human well-being, including literacy, education, wealth, sanitation, health, democratization and reduction in violence’.[6]

The naive view of information is perhaps most succinctly captured in Google’s mission statement ‘to organize the world’s information and make it universally accessible and useful’. Google’s answer to Goethe’s warnings is that while a single apprentice pilfering his master’s secret spell book is likely to cause disaster, when a lot of apprentices are given free access to all the world’s information, they will not only create useful enchanted brooms but also learn to handle them wisely.

GOOGLE VERSUS GOETHE

It must be stressed that there are numerous cases in which having more information has indeed enabled humans to understand the world better and to make wiser use of their power. Consider, for example, the dramatic reduction in child mortality. Johann Wolfgang von Goethe was the eldest of seven siblings, but only he and his sister Cornelia got to celebrate their seventh birthday. Disease carried off their brother Hermann Jacob at age six, their sister Catharina Elisabeth at age four, their sister Johanna Maria at age two, their brother Georg Adolf at age eight months, and a fifth, unnamed brother was stillborn. Cornelia then died from disease at twenty-six, leaving Johann Wolfgang as the sole survivor from their family.[7]